

NL owners set sights on Feeney

Chub Feeney is under fire from one segment of owners and faces a fight next month at the major league winter meetings in Los Angeles to keep his job as president of the National League. The decision must be made this year under the terms of his contract with the league.

The odds are that Feeney, whose contract runs out on Dec. 31, 1977, will be re-hired for at least three more years, but it's almost certain he will have to agree to move the league offices to New York. Some of the owners are adamant on that point, but the reason escapes me. If a move were made, it would be just as sensible to go to Chicago.

Feeney is a little bitter about the owners trying to get him fired. "I just wish people would come out in the open and say where they stand," Chub said. "I've worked hard at this job. I haven't had a vacation in seven years."

There are reports that John McHale, the president of the Montreal Expos, who haven't prospered under his leadership, is the top candidate to succeed Feeney if a change is made. But he lacks support.

Did you know the Phillies have now lost 11 postseason games in succession since winning their first game of the 1915 World Series from the Boston Red Sox, and that they are the only team active from 1901 to the present which has never won a World Series title . . . Former Phillies' coach Andy Cohen, now a robust 72, is the baseball coach at the University of Texas El Paso. Andy is the only unbeaten manager in Phillies' history. He ran the team for one game when Eddie Sawyer quit after one game in 1960 before Gene Mauch arrived.

Despite the opposition from Cincinnati President Bob Howsam and Phillies' owner Ruly Carpenter, it seems only a matter of time before the National League adds two more teams. When that happens, we may see each major league divided into three divisions, thereby producing more play-off games and a further lowering of the quality of play and players . . . Commissioner Bowie Kuhn is ready to push hard for the NL to adopt the Designated Hitter. For the life of me I can't understand why opposition to that silly gimmick is said to be crumbling.

Peter Bavasi may be fully capable of running the Toronto Blue Jays, but if it were my money I would have hired a more experienced executive for general manager and one that was completely familiar with the American League, not the National. Most of the players the Blue Jays have signed (outside the AL expansion draft) are players who failed to make the grade with San Diego,

Allen Lewis on baseball

where young Bavasi worked under his father, Buzzy, and on whom the Padres have given up.

Tony Taylor is trying to land a coaching job with another big league club, and I think he's making a mistake. Balancing the worth of a 20th year in the pension plan against what might be a lifetime spot with the Phillies seems foolhardy. If the popular Tony gets a coaching job somewhere else, he could be fired when

the manager is. With the Phils as a fifth coach he's be relatively secure no matter who is managing . . . Former big league infielder Bob Aspromonte has been awarded \$675,000 from the manufacturer and seller of auto battery jump cables. The terrible-temperel Aspro claimed the cables were responsible for an accident that cost him the sight in his right eye, and a Texas court jury in Houston made the award.

"We've had the Industrial Revolution and the Agricultural Revolution. Now the Baseball Revolution, and it's been coming since World War II," said Cardinal General Manager Bing Devine at the re-entry draft in new

York. "You have to live with it." . . . Red Sox infielder Rico Petrocelli, a star just a few short years ago, has been offered for sale and nobody wants him.

The Phillies have named former Penn State star Cal Emery to manage their Oklahoma city farm club. Lee Elia, Mike Compton and Ruben Amaro, making his managerial debut at Auburn, are the other system managers . . . Phils sold Pitcher John Montague (14-6 at Oklahoma City) to Seattle . . . Bob Luria is shaking up the Giants' front-office staff. GM Jerry Donovan is becoming a consultant, and PR Director John Taddeucci quit.

Beginning hunter makes case for 'must' safety training

I lost a friend the other day. Nice guy, too. I hadn't known him long and I was looking forward to knowing him better. Careless gun handling was the reason our acquaintance terminated.

No, he didn't shoot himself, or anyone else, but the potential was certainly there. Not willfully, mind you. He's a fine gentleman otherwise, with a lovely wife and two handsome kids. Committing a violent act is something he's not capable of. But he handles firearms stupidly.

Bill Williams (not his real name, of course) didn't hunt as a young man. He worked in a steel mill for seven years after graduation from high school. Put himself through college and is now employed as a successful CPA.

I met him at a friend's house two years ago and he indicated that he was about to take up hunting. Several of the guys at his office hunted and he wanted to get in on what sounded like a healthy, companionable sport. I suggested at the time that he take the Pennsylvania Game Commission hunter safety course. He had never hunted before.

"Do I have to?" Bill asked. I told him he didn't, and that only first-time hunters under the age of 16 were required to. "Well, then, I don't think I will. After all, I'm no kid any more. And I'm certainly smart enough not to shoot some farmer's cow."

Bill and I got together for a hunt last week. He grumbled a little when I told him that I don't hunt small game with anyone who is not wearing some item of blazing orange but

By JIM BASHLINE



out right here and you'd be caught flatfooted . . . I'm going to stay ready."

We intended to hunt all day but, by noon, I'd had enough bobbing and weaving to last a lifetime. I finally told him I was through for the day. My nerves just wouldn't stand anymore of his careless gun actions. I unloaded my gun, slipped it into the case and climbed into the car. He was more than a little peeved and tossed his gun—loaded—into the back seat. At that, I blew my top.

"Look, you clown, you've pulled every unsafe act in the book today and now you've capped it by putting a loaded gun in my car. Not only is that the height of stupidity, but it's also against the law."

"Oh, what's the big deal?" he

sniffed. "All the pro gun posters say that guns don't kill people; people kill people. That gun by itself won't hurt anyone."

"Right you are," I said, "but this people doesn't want to be killed by you people . . . Unload it right now."

I hope Bill takes a hunter safety course. In fact, I wish it were mandatory for all hunters, regardless of age, to pass a firearm safety course. It would be helpful to the hunter image across this nation if the hunters themselves would press for such a measure. Better for us to press for it before the opponents of hunting and firearms ownership manage to do it for us. I'm sure their version of "hunter safety" would be considerably more stringent.

It isn't always a novice hunter like Bill who makes the shooting accident news item. Too often it's hunters with some years of "experience" who goof up.

Shooting another human being at close range is not a hunting accident. It isn't an accident at all. It is downright stupidity. "Victim was struck in the chest while companion was unloading gun" is the sort of news item that should never occur.

